TOP SECRET

THE WHITE HOUSE
WASHINGTON

To the President -

3 September 1945

MEMORANDUM FOR COMMODORE VARDAMAN:

President Roosevelt and Chiang Kai-shek met in Cairo from 22 to 26 November 1943. I have found no record in the Roosevelt papers now in the White House of an agreement made by President Roosevelt with Chiang Kai-shek for the United States to furnish China with arms and equipment for 90 divisions. Neither the War Department nor the Secretariat of the Joint Chiefs of Staff are aware of such an agreement. However, Mr. Harry Hopkins informed me this morning by long-distance telephone that President Roosevelt did make such an agreement.

I talked with Mr. Hopkins at 1110. Mr. Hopkins said that the Secretary of State had called him 15 minutes earlier on the same subject. Mr. Hopkins gave the full story, so far as he could remember it, to the Secretary and he repeated all the information to me.

Mr. Hopkins recalls very distinctly a meeting at Cairo at which were present only President Roosevelt, Chiang Kai-shek, Madam Chiang Kai-shek and himself. Chiang described the needs of the Chinese Army, and in response to his plea, President Roosevelt made a "flat promise" to provide equipment for 30 Chinese divisions at once and equipment for 60 additional divisions at a later date.

Mr. Hopkins said no memorandum of the conversation of this meeting was ever made, and he does not believe that President Roosevelt consulted the Joint Chiefs of Staff before or after he made his promise to the Chinese.

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Mr. Hopkins said that he talked with President Roosevelt immediately after the Chiangs had left and he remarked that the President had promised a very great deal. He asked the President how we could carry out the agreement should the war end and Lend-Lease cease before all the equipment was supplied the Chinese. President Roosevelt replied that he supposed the Chinese would then "buy the stuff."

Mr. Hopkins stated that he believes President Roosevelt's purpose in making this promise was his desire to insure that China remain in the war; his intention to strengthen, if possible, Chiang's hand in dealing with recalcitrant Chinese factions; and his hope that China could ultimately become a great power. The President was using every means at his command at that time to prevent Chiang's Government from collapsing.

Mr. Hopkins will search his personal files as soon as he returns to New York but he warned that he is sure he will find no written record of the Cairo meeting. He emphasized that all of the facts stated above are from "memory only."

Mr. Hopkins made the concluding comment in a half joking - half serious manner that, if the Chinese were now trying to hold the U.S. to President Roosevelt's verbal agreement at Cairo, President Truman should reply that he could find no record of it.

Very respectfully,

George M. Elsey

GEORGE M. ELSEY,
Lieutenant, USNR.